Central Ideas

Rousseau occupies a critical position in the realm of political philosophy. He is predominantly known for his contribution towards the "theory of social contract". As a social contractualist by conviction, ***Rousseau*** sought to unearth the origin of state as an expression of the "general will". He attributed the origin of state as a consequence of two phases – "state of nature" and "social contract".

State of Nature

Unlike ***Hobbes***, ***Rousseau***'s proposition of state of nature was an epitome of perfect liberty, perfect equality and perfect innocence. He also identifies it with a more peaceful, pleasant and idyllic environment. The man in his state of nature lived in solitude characterized by a care-free living with no desires. Despite the inconsistency in terms of a settled life, and inarticulate speech, the life was shaped by contentment, independence, self-sufficiency and prosperity. Absence of wickedness paved the way for idyllic happiness. As he says, "supreme bliss" was the norm of the time.

In due course, the status quo was threatened by changes in terms of sophistication of human life. He acknowledged a number of factors ranging from the divergences in climate, season and soil to organized profession and private property as responsible for challenging the sustenance of the state of nature. In the view of ***Rousseau***, human progress and rational advancement accompanied by the revolution in the conduct of life and human thought brought a new layer of evils in its wagon. He identifies the origin of inequality with this shower of changes that shook the fabric of the state of nature. The concept of private ownership created a new cleavage at the social sphere – rich and poor. In his words, "the first man who after enclosing a piece of land said to himself 'this is mine' and found people simply to believe him, was the real founder of civil society".

The period was made to witness a chain of wars, murders and rifts between the rich and poor. This new order sanctioned evils at a universal scale that were unfound in the savage state. An unavoidable culmination of these turn of events was the rise of inequality and a strata of masters and slaves. ***Rousseau*** opines that there are two premises on which a savage acts. Firstly, a human is driven by the need of self-preservation and out of the interest of his/her own welfare. Secondly, the fear of death. He finds the genesis of rationality and reason in this emotional consciousness. ***Rousseau*** is of the view of that the humans by nature are incapable of thinking. Civil society is viewed as antithetical to nature and it is apparently an outcome of the march of human reason. He insists on the slogan of "returning to nature". His demand for the retrospection to the nature does not tantamount to a prescription for the collapse of the newly woven social fabric, but the rule of nature. Such a call necessarily unveils ***Rousseau***'s revelation that it is the philosophy and reason that allured the human life to entropy.

Social Contract

The idyllic character of the state of nature was short-lived. The emerging template of human complexities defined by economic advancement and social evolution facilitated only havoc. Humans were left with no alternative, but to constitute the civil state. It

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